

STUDY SHEET - BLOCK 2: CHAPTER TWO (Marley's Ghost)

1. Plot (Trama)

Scrooge walks home to the very old, dark, and silent rooms where he lives (which used to belong to his partner, Marley) [cite: 1, 2]. As he arrives, he experiences his first supernatural encounter: he sees Marley's face in the large knocker on his front door [cite: 1, 2]. Inside, strange things start happening, such as all the bells in the house beginning to ring loudly. Suddenly, the ghost of Jacob Marley appears. He is wrapped in a heavy chain made of cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, and ledgers. At first, Scrooge tries to deny what he is seeing, blaming the vision on an indigestion (saying his famous "humbug!").

Marley explains that he forged this heavy chain himself during his life because he was greedy and only cared about making money, ignoring the suffering of other people. He is now condemned to wander the earth with no rest. He gives Scrooge a terrible warning: Scrooge's own chain is already much longer and heavier than Marley's.

However, Marley brings a message of hope. He tells Scrooge that he still has one last chance to escape this fate: he will be visited by **Three Spirits** over the next few nights. After giving his warning, Marley's ghost floats out of the window into the night, joining hundreds of other suffering phantoms.

2. Characters (Personaggi)

- **Ebenezer Scrooge:** He is initially skeptical and tries to fight his fear with sarcasm. However, as the encounter progresses, he becomes terrified. We begin to see the first cracks in his cold exterior as he is forced to face the supernatural and the consequences of his actions.
- **Jacob Marley (The Ghost):** Scrooge's deceased business partner. He is deeply regretful of his past life. He acts as a messenger and a mirror for Scrooge, showing him exactly what his future will be if he doesn't change.

3. Themes (Tematiche)

- **Greed and Consequences (Avidità e Conseguenze):** The chain Marley wears is a

physical representation of his sins. Dickens uses this to show that our selfish actions in life have heavy consequences.

- **Social Responsibility (Responsabilità sociale):** Marley famously says that "Mankind was my business." This means that humans should care for one another, and business/money should not be the only purpose in life.
- **Redemption (Redenzione):** Marley's visit offers Scrooge a chance for salvation. It introduces the idea that it is never too late to change.
- **The Supernatural (Il soprannaturale):** The dark atmosphere, the transforming door knocker, and the ghosts create a classic gothic mood, typical of a Victorian ghost story.

4. Useful Vocabulary (Vocabolario utile)

- **Knocker:** Batacchio della porta (dove Scrooge vede il volto di Marley [cite: 1, 2])
- **Ghost / Phantom / Spirit:** Fantasma / Spirito
- **Chain:** Catena
- **Cash-boxes and ledgers:** Casseforti e registri contabili (gli oggetti che formano la catena di Marley, simboli della sua avidità)
- **To forge:** Forgiare, fabbricare (Marley ha "forgiato" la sua catena in vita)
- **Warning:** Avvertimento
- **Mankind:** Umanità

5. Possible Questions & Short Answers (Domande per la verifica)

- **Q1: What is the first strange thing Scrooge sees when he arrives home?**
Answer: When he goes to put his key in the door, he sees Jacob Marley's face in the large door knocker [cite: 1, 2].
- **Q2: What is Marley's ghost wearing and what does it represent?**
Answer: The ghost is wearing a heavy chain made of cash-boxes, keys, and ledgers. It represents his greed and his obsession with business and money during his life.
- **Q3: What does Marley tell Scrooge about his (Scrooge's) chain?**
Answer: Marley warns Scrooge that his own chain is already much longer and heavier than Marley's, because Scrooge is still living a selfish life.
- **Q4: What is Marley's warning to Scrooge?**
Answer: Marley warns him to change his life and tells him that he will be visited by three Spirits to give him a chance to escape Marley's terrible fate.